

The most significant features of Windows 8 are available in all editions while the differentiating features of Windows 8 Pro and Windows 8 Enterprise are useful only to enterprises.

But do I really need it?

If you're buying a new laptop, chances are high that it will ship with Windows 8. In that case, there's no escaping it. Unless it comes pre-installed, we don't really find it to be a compelling upgrade. Let's elaborate a bit on that.

Windows 8 changes the way you use your system. There's no start menu or visible search box when you press the Windows key. You just start typing what you want to search. Much like Mac and Linux, this OS has 'hot corners' which give you access to shortcuts by placing your mouse near the screen corners. Half of the control panel's functions are present in the new 'PC settings' app (it's a Modern UI app). There are two Internet Explorers – one for the desktop, another for the Modern UI. While there are architectural changes under the hood, they don't show up all that much. The UI changes are the most significant difference between Windows 7 and Windows 8.

While Microsoft has got its share of brickbats for the interface change, there's also been some excellent feedback. One of the biggest advancements that Windows 8 brings to the table is the ability to multi-task. Besides Snap Apps, you have a Charms bar on the right-hand side to open settings, plugged-in-devices, start screen and search and share files whenever you need to. While many have reported that these features are great and help get mundane tasks done quickly and easily, complaints have also been in abundance.

If what we just told about the changes in UI sounds a bit intimidating and you're hesitant to shell out money for the Modern UI screen (the 'start screen'), you'd be okay staying away from Windows 8. If not, read on. Most applications which can work on Windows 7 will work on Windows 8. Windows 8 integrates better with the cloud than any previous version of Windows. You can have settings synced on different PCs.

Whether or not to upgrade depends on how badly you need the new features. If you read the last issue of Digit, you'll remember us telling you that Windows 8 is faster to boot and takes the torture much better than

NOTE

The terms 'Client' and 'Server', in context of Remote Desktop mean 'Controlling' computer and 'Controlled' computer, in that order.

Windows 8 can't be used for requesting remote help because it can't act as a server.